# WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

*Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets*

# BELIZE

Americas

*Information current as of October 2026*

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

## WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

### KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

| Location / Region | Strategic Importance | Priority Sectors |
|---|---|---|
| Belize City | Largest city and commercial centre, home to the Port of Belize and the main international airport; focus of a proposed cargo and four-berth cruise port PPP valued at around $410–450 million | Port logistics, cruise tourism, financial and business services |
| Belmopan | Capital and seat of government, ministries and the Central Bank; well placed on the George Price Highway linking the coast to Cayo and the Guatemalan border | Public administration, professional services, construction |
| Ambergris Caye / San Pedro and the Barrier Reef | Leading overnight-tourism destination on the largest coral reef in the Americas, and host of the Belize Investment Summit 2025 | Resort and hospitality, real estate, marine and blue-economy tourism |
| Northern Belize and the Chetumal border corridor | Gateway to southern Mexico, promoted by the government as a logistics, industrial and commercial corridor, with Commercial Free Zone incentives available | Cross-border trade, logistics, sugar and agro-processing |
| Cayo District | Site of the Mollejon, Chalillo and Vaca hydro plants (about 51 MW) on the Macal River, and of the planned $20 million sugar refinery at Valley of Peace | Renewable energy, sugar refining, agriculture, eco-tourism |
| Southern Belize (Stann Creek and Toledo) | Agricultural and coastal belt producing bananas, citrus and seafood, with growing coastal tourism | Bananas and citrus, aquaculture and fisheries, tourism |
| Designated Processing Areas and Commercial Free Zones | Incentive zones offering duty and tax exemptions for manufacturing, agro-processing, IT-enabled services and trading activity | Light manufacturing, agro-processing, BPO, trade and warehousing |

### INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Belize Trade and Investment Development Service (BELTRAIDE), the national investment promotion agency, which manages incentive programmes and provides facilitation; 100% foreign ownership is permitted in almost all sectors
- Fiscal Incentives Act No. 4 of 2023, offering exemptions from import duty, revenue replacement duty, excise and business tax for approved activities, with an initial five-year term renewable up to 25 years, plus dedicated MSME and one-off programmes

- Designated Processing Areas (DPA Act No. 27 of 2018), offering import duty, tax, property tax and GST exemptions for up to 10 years (renewable) for manufacturing, agro-processing, aquaculture and IT-enabled services
- Commercial Free Zones (Free Zones Act 2005), offering a 10-year exemption from income, capital gains and corporate taxes, dividend-tax exemption for up to 25 years and duty-free inputs
- Central Bank of Belize exchange control framework: registering inward investment secures "Approved Status", under which repatriation of capital is ordinarily approved routinely; the Belize dollar is pegged at BZ$2 = $1
- Public-private partnership and independent power producer routes, including BEL's up to 80 MW utility-scale solar procurement under the IFC-advised Scaling Solar programme (25-year build-own-operate) and the Port of Belize cargo and cruise PPP
- Qualified Retired Person programme for applicants aged 45+ with at least $2,000 a month in foreign income, offering income-tax and import-duty exemptions

### MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Belize in October 2026 offers a stable, US-dollar-pegged economy with a strong tourism franchise and a growing pipeline of infrastructure and energy investment. After strong growth in 2024, the World Bank estimates growth of 2.6% in 2025 and projects 2.4% in 2026, and GDP rose 1.4% in the second quarter of 2026, led by services (+3.4%) and trade (+5.5%), with cruise arrivals up 29%. Overnight visitors reached 551,698 in 2025, about 9.6% above 2019, while cruise passengers rose 8.1% to 967,214. Public debt has fallen from a 2020 peak of 103.3% of GDP, supported by a debt-for-marine-protection swap, to around 66% of GDP in May 2026, and reserves cover about 4.2 months of imports. Investor momentum is visible: the 2025 Belize Investment Summit recorded preliminary commitments exceeding BZ$1.5 billion, the government acquired the Macal River hydro plants and a one-third stake in Belize Electricity Limited from Fortis in October 2025, and a $20 million sugar refinery is planned to serve CARICOM.

Belize's main structural challenge is the scale and openness of a small economy concentrated in tourism and agriculture and dependent on imported fuel. This shows in the 2026 inflation pick-up to 4.4% in August, driven mainly by fuel and electricity costs, and in exposure to hurricanes and crop disease. The policy response is building resilience: a Least Cost Expansion Plan prioritising domestic solar and battery storage, an 80 MW solar tender launched in January 2026 to reduce reliance on electricity imports, a $27.5 million grid-modernisation package from the Caribbean Development Bank and Canada, and IMF-backed fiscal reforms. The IMF notes that growth above about 2% depends on expanding hotel and airlift capacity, creating clear openings for investors in hospitality, aviation, ports, renewable energy and agro-processing.

## INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

### KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

| Issue | Potential Impact | Possible Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| Tourism capacity constraints | The IMF identifies hotel room and flight capacity as the main limits on growth above about 2%, even as visitor demand grows | A direct opportunity for hotel, airlift and cruise-port investment, supported by fiscal incentives for tourism projects |
| Energy costs and import dependence | Imported fuel and power raise business costs; fuel and electricity tariffs lifted inflation to 4.4% in August 2026 | The 80 MW solar programme, hydro ownership and grid modernisation are reducing reliance on imports and creating IPP opportunities |
| Hurricane and climate exposure | As a low-lying Caribbean coastal state, Belize faces periodic storm and climate risks to tourism and agriculture | Use resilient design and insurance; resilience investment, supported by multilateral lenders, is itself a growing market |
| Agricultural output volatility | Crop disease has affected sugarcane and citrus, with citrus output down by almost two-thirds in Q2 2026 | Diversify sourcing and invest in disease-resistant varieties, irrigation and processing; marine exports rose 33.6% in the same quarter |
| Exchange control requirements | Foreign exchange transactions are regulated by the Central Bank, and profit and loan remittances may require | Register investment with the Central Bank at entry to obtain Approved Status, under which capital repatriation is ordinarily |

| Issue | Potential Impact | Possible Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| | supporting evidence | routine |
| Territorial claims before the ICJ | Guatemala's claim and a Honduras case over the Sapodilla Cayes are before the International Court of Justice, with hearings scheduled for February and March 2027 | Both disputes are being resolved peacefully through international law; monitor proceedings for projects in the south and in border areas |
| Public debt and governance reforms | Debt is well below its 2020 peak but still around 66% of GDP, and the IMF has urged further consolidation and closing remaining AML/CFT gaps | Apply robust due diligence and compliance; continued reform supports financing conditions and investor confidence |

### INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Belize's risk profile is that of a small, open and politically stable democracy with a credible currency peg, a strong tourism brand and a demonstrated record of debt reduction. The 2025 election returned Prime Minister John Briceño's government with a large majority, giving continuity to its investment and infrastructure agenda, and the BZ$2 = $1 peg is backed by reserves of around four months of imports. The main sensitivities, namely imported energy costs, climate exposure and agricultural volatility, are well understood and are being addressed through domestic solar, hydro ownership, grid modernisation and multilateral support. Territorial questions with Guatemala and Honduras are being settled peacefully at the International Court of Justice. Investors should register capital with the Central Bank at entry, plan for hurricane-season contingencies and apply standard AML/CFT due diligence, while positioning for the capacity gaps in tourism, logistics and energy that offer the clearest upside.

### MARKET ACCESS

Belize is the only country that belongs to both CARICOM and the Central American Integration System (SICA), giving it a natural bridge role between the Caribbean, Central America and Mexico. Through CARICOM it applies the Common External Tariff and benefits from the CARIFORUM–EU and CARIFORUM–UK Economic Partnership Agreements, and it is a WTO member. It also has a partial scope agreement with Guatemala, an Economic Cooperation Agreement with Taiwan covering around 199 products, and access to the US market under the Caribbean Basin Trade Partnership Act. The United Kingdom and the United States are the main export markets, each taking around 23% of exports, chiefly sugar, bananas, citrus and marine products, while the US, China and Mexico are leading suppliers. The Chetumal border corridor and the planned Port of Belize expansion are designed to strengthen Belize's role as a logistics gateway into CARICOM.

## WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

### INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

| Actor | Why It Matters | Waverley Engagement Angle |
|---|---|---|
| Office of the Prime Minister (John Briceño) | Leads economic policy and, with the Ministry of Investment, champions flagship projects such as the Port of Belize PPP and the Investment Summit | Primary reference point for Belize's strategic direction and major project priorities |
| BELTRAIDE | National investment promotion agency managing fiscal incentives, DPAs and investor facilitation | Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentive applications |
| Central Bank of Belize | Monetary authority; maintains the BZ$2 = $1 peg and administers exchange control and Approved Status registration | Essential for registering inward investment and securing repatriation rights |
| Ministry of Investment | Houses the Investment Policy and Compliance Unit and leads investment promotion missions abroad | Relevant for policy dialogue, incentive compliance and government-to-government initiatives |
| Belize Electricity Limited (BEL) | National utility and buyer under the 80 MW solar IPP programme, implementing the Least Cost Expansion Plan | Key counterpart for renewable-energy and storage investment |

| Actor | Why It Matters | Waverley Engagement Angle |
|---|---|---|
| Port of Belize Ltd | Operator of the main cargo port and sponsor of the proposed cargo and cruise expansion PPP | Counterpart for logistics, terminal-operation and cruise-port investment |
| Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Foreign Trade | Leads trade policy, CARICOM and SICA relations and the ICJ cases | Relevant for market-access agreements and regional positioning |

## CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Belize Chamber of Commerce and Industry (BCCI) is the principal private-sector body and a useful source of practical market intelligence. BELTRAIDE and the Office of the Prime Minister organise the Belize Investment Summit, whose 2025 edition drew more than 600 participants and whose next edition is planned for 2027, and the government also promotes Belize at regional forums such as Mexico's AMERIC Business Summit. The Inter-American Development Bank, Caribbean Development Bank, World Bank Group and IFC are active in energy, roads and resilience, with the IFC advising on the solar IPP programme. The Belize Tourism Board is the key channel for hospitality investors.

## INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Belize suits investors seeking a US-dollar-pegged, English-speaking, common-law jurisdiction with access to both CARICOM and Central America: hospitality and aviation investors addressing the hotel and airlift capacity gap; renewable-energy developers and IPPs bidding into the solar and storage programme; port, logistics and cruise-terminal operators targeting the Port of Belize PPP and the Mexico corridor; agro-processing, aquaculture and food investors using DPA and fiscal incentives; and BPO and IT-enabled service providers. Investors comfortable with a small market and climate-resilient planning will find a stable, welcoming environment with strong government support for priority projects.

## FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage BELTRAIDE and confirm incentive eligibility
Open early dialogue with the investment agency to identify the best-fit regime among the Fiscal Incentives Act, Designated Processing Areas and Commercial Free Zones.

STEP 2: Register investment with the Central Bank at entry
Obtain Approved Status for inward capital so that future repatriation of capital and profits follows a routine approval process.

STEP 3: Position for PPP and IPP tenders
Track BEL's solar and storage procurement and the Port of Belize PPP, and prequalify early with local partners and advisers.

STEP 4: Target the tourism capacity gap
Assess hotel, airlift and cruise-related opportunities where visitor demand is outpacing supply, using available fiscal incentives.

STEP 5: Build climate resilience into project design
Incorporate hurricane-resilient construction, insurance and supply-chain contingencies, and explore multilateral co-financing for resilience-linked investment.